Things became so bad that RSS Spokesperson M.G. Vaidya wrote a signed piece in *Organiser* in 2001 arguing that the 'RSS believes in the eminence of the party, whether in power or not, must be maintained. No question should be raised about its supremacy … the workers of the party should not play second fiddle to the legislative wing, wagging their tails at the Government's bidding.' Such a party, he said, would be 'useless'.[66] These familial discords became so common that *India Today* would write tongue-in-cheek, 'Every family has an uncle it is embarrassed about. For the NDA government led by Atal Behari Vajpayee, it is the Sangh Parivar patriarchs in Nagpur.'[67] That is certainly not the case with the Modi government, where the two move much more in tandem with one another.

It would be simplistic to see the penetration of the BJP by RSS leaders as a permanent Sangh conspiracy to micro-manage. The pulls and pressures of politics are far more nuanced. BJP's Rajya Sabha MP Swapan Dasgupta analysed this perceptively in 2009 when he argued that the 'overwhelming majority' of RSS workers in 'all probability, vote for BJP candidates', nurture a 'distaste for the Nehruvian legacy', and that the more ambitious of them may also see linking with the BJP as a 'worthwhile career graph'. 'Indeed, within the BJP, there is a discernible divide between those who came to the party from the RSS and those who entered through other routes.' Yet, the RSS constitutes 'only a small fraction of those who drive the BJP at the grassroots'.[68]

As Chapter 8 of this book shows, the BJP's own expansion since 2014 means that its membership base had significantly dwarfed that of the RSS by 2019. Further, as Dasgupta pointed out, the demands of politics often ensure that even imports from the RSS or its affiliates 'end up disavowing the austere exclusivism of the RSS and accepting the more worldly logic of political mobilisation. Kalyan Singh moulded himself as a caste leader of western Uttar Pradesh; Narendra Modi became a passionate advocate of modernity and efficient governance; and Atal Bihari Vajpayee took to consensual coalition-building. All of them came into conflict with the RSS at one point or another.'[69]